

## NTL22 Enrichment

†1. **Bible customs—the wedding procession:** “The bridegroom set out with the bride from the house of her parents, and there followed a grand procession all the way to his house. The streets of Asiatic cities were dark, and it was necessary that anybody venturing forth at night should carry a lamp or torch (cf. Psa. 119:105). Those invited guests, who did not go to the bride’s home were allowed to join the procession along the way, and go with the whole group to the marriage feast. Without a torch or lamp they couldn’t join the procession, or enter the bridegroom’s house.[20] (Fred H. Wight, *Manners and Customs of Bible Lands* (Chicago: Moody Press, 1953) 31-32)

†2. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “In the parable, oil can be purchased at the market. In our lives the oil of preparedness is accumulated drop by drop in righteous living. Attendance at sacrament meetings adds oil to our lamps, drop by drop over the years. Fasting, family prayer, home teaching, control of bodily appetites, preaching the gospel, studying the scriptures—each act of dedication and obedience is a drop added to our store. Deeds of kindness, payment of offerings and tithes, chaste thoughts and actions, marriage in the covenant for eternity—these, too, contribute importantly to the oil with which we can at midnight refuel our exhausted lamps” (*Faith Precedes the Miracle* [1972], 256).

†3. **Elder Carlos E. Asay:** “I knew of a man who never looked up; consequently, he never lived—he just existed. Over a period of years this man became a slave to alcohol. Drink by drink he accumulated all the miserable habits and characteristics of a drunkard. He walked the streets in a stupor of mind and with an unsteady step. When greeted by friends passing by, his response was a feeble wave of the hand or an almost inaudible grunt. Physically, he was a wreck.

To avoid people and conversation, this alcoholic would stagger off the path or into the gutter, for that was the direction of his look. He seemed oblivious to the people, the things, and the events around him.

Many pitied this man who had lost health, pride, purpose, family love, and other blessings. They observed his shackled condition but did little or nothing to remove or help him remove the shackles. Others, without compassion ridiculed him.

After many years of suffering, some unselfish people helped this man work a miracle. These friends invested countless hours of loving care, much kindly persuasion, many fervent prayers, and all else required to reform the man. In the process of repentance, (1) he allowed the written word of God to nourish his impoverished soul;

(2) he fixed his eyes upon a living prophet and tuned his ears to the prophet’s teachings; and (3) he also rekindled faith in himself by exercising faith in Christ.

In time he gained the confidence and strength to walk with steady stride on the sidewalk. He was successful in breaking Satan’s bonds. He straightened his shoulders, looked people in the eye, and began to converse with others.

More important, he assumed his rightful role as a loved husband and respected father. I’m told that when this man—this new man—stood in church and bore his testimony, he expressed these thoughts:

“You’ll never know how wonderful it is to recognize people by the smiles on their faces rather than the dust on their shoes.”

“You’ll never know how wonderful it is to gaze upward at a blue sky rather than downward at darkened ground.”

“You’ll never know how wonderful it is to return home from work and have your children run toward you with love, rather than away from you with fear.” (“[Look to God and Live](#),” *Ensign*, November 1978.)

†4. **Elder Carl B. Cook:** “At the end of a particularly tiring day toward the end of **my first week** as a General Authority, my briefcase was overloaded and my mind was preoccupied with the question “How can I possibly do this?” I left the office of the Seventy and entered the elevator of the Church Administration Building. As the elevator descended, my head was down and I stared blankly at the floor.

“The door opened and someone entered, but I didn’t look up. As the door closed, I heard someone ask, ‘**What are you looking at down there?**’ I recognized that voice—it was President Thomas S. Monson.

“I quickly looked up and responded, ‘**Oh, nothing.**’ (I’m sure that clever response inspired confidence in my abilities!)

“But he had seen my subdued countenance and my heavy briefcase. He smiled and lovingly suggested, while pointing heavenward, ‘**It is better to look up!**’ As we traveled down one more level, he cheerfully explained that he was on his way to the temple. When he bid me farewell, his parting glance spoke again to my heart, ‘**Now, remember, it is better to look up.**’

“As we parted, the words of a scripture came to mind: ‘Believe in God; believe that he is ... ; believe that he has all wisdom, and all power, both in heaven and in earth.’[1] As I thought of Heavenly Father and Jesus Christ’s power, my heart found the comfort I had sought in vain from the floor of that descending elevator.” (“[It Is Better to Look Up](#),” *Ensign*, November 2011.)

#### †5. [Look Up \(Acland\):](#)

Look up, sad soul, through thy distress.  
Thy parched and barren wilderness  
Can be revived and made to bloom.  
Let God's pure light dispel thy gloom.

Look up, reach, thy holy friend  
Stands watching, waiting to attend.  
His love's pure, his grace divine  
Can heal a sorrow such as thine.

Look up, O man, with hope and faith,  
The way is clear, the path is laid.  
Let living waters heal thy soul.  
The Savior's hand can make thee whole.

(Text: Francis Acland  
Submitted Hymn Texts, Submitted Music (1992-1997) )

#### †6. [The Ten Virgins—Bible Videos.](#)

†7. **Elder Marvin J. Ashton:** "Let me mention a few gifts that are not always evident or noteworthy but that are very important. Among these may be your gifts—gifts not so evident but nevertheless real and valuable.

"Let us review some of these less-conspicuous gifts: the gift of asking; the gift of listening; the gift of hearing and using a still, small voice; the gift of being able to weep; the gift of avoiding contention; the gift of being agreeable; the gift of avoiding vain repetition; the gift of seeking that which is righteous; the gift of not passing judgment; the gift of looking to God for guidance; the gift of being a disciple; the gift of caring for others; the gift of being able to ponder; the gift of offering prayer; the gift of bearing a mighty testimony; and the gift of receiving the Holy Ghost" ("[There Are Many Gifts](#)," *Ensign*, Nov 1987, 20)

†8. **Nancy Jensen:** "One of my children came in, said that Brother Newton Hall's folks were out of bread. Had none that day. I put...our flour in [a] sack to send up to Brother Hall's. Just then Brother Hall came in.

"Says I, 'Brother Hall, how are you out for flour[?]'

"'Brother Millett, we have none.'

"'Well, Brother Hall, there is some in that sack. I have divided and was going to send it to you. Your children told mine that you were out.'

"Brother Hall began to cry. Said he had tried others. Could not get any. Went to the cedars and prayed to the Lord and the Lord told him to go to Joseph Millett.

"'Well, Brother Hall, you needn't bring this back if the Lord sent you for it. You don't owe me for it.' You can't tell how good it made me feel to know that the

Lord knew that there was such a person as Joseph Millett." (Eugene England, "[Without Purse or Scrip](#)," *New Era*, July 1975; also Boyd K. Packer, *Ensign*, May 1980; also Joseph B. Wirthlin, *Ensign*, December 2000; also Thomas S. Monson, *Liahona*, December 2006)

[Note: Nancy Jensen has many other fine thoughts here about these three preparatory parables. See [New Testament Lesson #22](#)]

†9. **Lenet H. Read:** "The real Gifts the Lord was bestowing upon Israel were His teachings, His Priesthood, His sacred ordinances and His sacred covenants. For He was the one "travelling into a far country"—back into His Father's presence. And He was leaving 'His own servants, and delivering unto them His goods.' And the question He was asking them was: 'What are you going to do with these precious Gifts I have given you?' ([New Testament 22](#))

[Note: Lenet H. Read also provides some unique insights about these three linked preparatory parables. See [New Testament 22](#).]

#### †10. **Gospel Talent:**

"With some [elders of the church] I am not well pleased, for they will not open their mouths, but they hide the talent which I have given unto them, because of the fear of man. And ... if they are not more faithful unto me, it shall be taken away, even that which they have... [The elders of the Church] have been sent to preach my gospel among the congregations of the wicked; wherefore, I give unto them a commandment, thus: Thou shalt not idle away thy time, neither shalt thou bury thy talent that it may not be known. (D&C 60:2-3, 13).